identity politics in their framing of the conflict, they posit that whereas the discrimination experienced by Kachin might be a proximal cause of conflict, underlying it is more fundamental disagreement about the distribution and form of political power — the kind of disagreement that Welsh and Huang suggest might be indicative of the return of the political to Myanmar more generally.

Jenny Hedström (2016) draws on work in feminist political economy to interpret Kachin women's responses to violence. By recounting how women negotiate and query the gendered roles assigned them, both in their ethno-nationalist struggle and in their households, Hedström urges us to think about how gender inequality is constitutive of conflict.

The engagement of Kachin women with questions of their inequality invites the possibility of a new kind of political activity to come. But it is unlike the embryonic politics through policymaking technical teams and legislative non-partisanship discussed in other chapters. Like Derrida's "democracy to come" (2005, p. 86; see also Mouffe 1993, p. 8), it calls for a militant political critique, with an emancipatory promise both for the women whose narratives it embraces, and for the scholarship of conflict in contemporary Myanmar.

That critique is, of course, rooted in the principle of equality that is essential for the political, insofar as the promise of equality through human organization makes the political possible (Arendt 1994, p. 301).[8] This promise also gives rise to the unavoidable and unending conflict over what equality means and how it is to be realized.

CONCLUSION

Whereas under military government the political was denied to people in Myanmar, today they are again sensing its promise. But, the contents of *Conflict in Myanmar* indicate that the political today also encounters two broadly interrelated threats. Neither of these threats emerges from or is inherently related to the persistence of conflict itself, which is necessary for the political. Rather, each relates to responses to conflict, to attempts to displace or deny conflict and their consequences.

One threat arises from those people who fearful of conflict and, understandably, tired of the violence that it has engendered for so long in Myanmar, aim to establish a kind of politics as technology that can